

2.2.1 Vital Statistics

Now why would anyone want to spend time, money, and other resources on visitors to a Web site? For the same reason that a shopkeeper wants to know the number and the details of visitors to his shop; for the same reason that everyone from little businesses to major companies spend fortunes on surveys and market research. After all, a Web site is a product, and like every manufacturer of a product—or one of its sellers—one should be able to modify, improve, and remodel one's product according to the tastes of the people you hope will buy it.

2.2.2 Advantages of Web tracking

- Tracking the kind of traffic a Web site receives would help the owner of the site to identify areas for database or Web site maintenance. For example, the number of failed searches for a particular term on the Web site could reveal data entry errors that need to be rectified.
- Information so gathered could be used to offer feedback to users on their use of the information retrieval system.
- To identify user needs by collecting data on the subjects and topics that are most searched for or clicked on.
- Effective tracking enables the development and improvement of the user interface and software by analysing user behaviour and navigation patterns.
- It identifies trends and changes in user behaviour and preferences, and ensures effective decision-making regarding the changes to be made in the nature and content of the site.
- Notes the geographical concentration of requests received by the Web site, indicating the shifts in demographic of the target audience.
- Provides information to site owners regarding the number of and location of new visitors.

Over the years, webmasters—the guys who create and maintain Web sites—have realised the above benefits of calculating statistics about Web site usage. Dozens of software products are now available in the market—like NetTracker, SurfSpy, WebTrends, TheCounter.com, etc.—which do the job of tracking for a Web site. However, the utility value of such software is limited and some-